A GLOBAL RISE

Around the world, both Covid cases and deaths are increasing

8%
Rise in new Covid cases in the week ending March 20

600,000
New cases in South Korea, the second-highest single-day rise in the world

97%
of Hong Kong's total Covid cases reported in the past month

3,500
Peak deaths for the US, the highest since vaccinations began last year

2
Deaths reported from mainland China, for the first time in a year

1.5
million new cases recorded in Germany; 1.2 million in Vietnam in the week ending March 20

PROTECTING THE VULNERABLE

Hong Kong, with the world's highest Covid death rate, had over half a million people over 70 who had not been vaccinated when the Omicron wave began. Close to 70 per cent of deaths in the city have been reported in this age group. Similarly, over 50 per cent of those aged above 80 in mainland China have not been fully vaccinated, and only 48 per cent of those above 70 have had a booster shot. "It is extremely important that Indians who are above 60 and with comorbid conditions be protected against Covid," says Dr V.K. Paul, chairman of the National Expert Group on Vaccine Administration for Covid-19 (NEGVAC). The decision for the government policy to prioritise boosters for the most vulnerable comes in the wake of global medical data highlighting the plight of the unvaccinated elderly. "In those who are immunocompromised, even a cold could turn deadly," says Dr Kataria.

In India, around 90 per cent of adults have been fully vaccinated and nearly 100 per cent have been partially vaccinated so far. Ten million healthcare and frontline workers and another 10 million people aged above 60 have received booster shots. A vaccine programme for 15- to 18-year-olds also began in January, with more than 75 per cent having received the first dose. The national vaccination programme was also expanded last week to include all above 60 years for booster doses and the country has begun child vaccination for the 12-14 age group. India is currently using four vaccines—the Oxford-AstraZeneca jab, known locally as Covishield; Covaxin by Indian firm Bharat Biotech; Russian-made Sputnik V; and now Corbevax. Covishield has accounted for over 90 per cent of the doses given to adults so far. The government has also authorised Cipla to import Moderna's vaccine, but the doses are yet to be made available in the market. In February, India also approved the single-dose vaccine, Sputnik Light.

According to the Bloomberg Global Vaccine Tracker, only 1.5 per cent of Indians have had a third booster dose. Globally, studies and experiences are showing the growing importance of the third shot. Surveillance data by Britain's NHS shows that vaccine effectiveness against symptomatic Covid is less than 20 per cent for both sub-variants 25 weeks or more after a second dose, but rises to roughly 70 per cent two to four weeks after a third dose. An interim analysis by AstraZeneca of its trials for a booster in the UK reaffirms that a third dose helps prevent symptomatic infection with Omicron after two doses of the same vaccine. "Many people aren't taking the booster doses in India and this is concerning. The booster might not prevent Covid infection but it will give the added immunity needed against hospitalisation and death," says Dr Ingale.



"VACCINES HELP PREVENT SYMPTOMATIC INFECTIONS, HOSPITALISATIONS AND DEATHS...BUT **THIS DOESN'T MEAN THAT COVID STILL CANNOT CLAIM LIVES**"

Dr SUSHILA KATARIA
Senior Director, Internal Medicine, Medanta Hospital

In fact, after the emergence of a new unnamed variant in Israel last week, which combines mutations from both BA.1 and BA.2, the UK has opened up a second booster dose to give even more protection to the vulnerable sections of the population. Global indications and medical studies reconfirm that booster coverage is going to be a crucial component in determining the impact of future Covid waves. ■